

Chapter

Master Your Mind Before Your Mind Masters You



Introduction: Who Is the Master of the Mind?

All of us set our minds on something — a serial, a picture, a match. The question is not whether the mind gets absorbed; the question is whether, when the need arises, we can pull it out just as easily. In this short discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji explains exactly this on the basis of the **sattvic intellect** and **sattvic resolve** described in the eighteenth chapter of the Shrimad Bhagavad Gita. The Gita describes the sattvic intellect this way:

**pravṛttiṁ ca nivṛttiṁ ca kāryākārye bhayābhaye
bandhaṁ mokṣaṁ ca yā vetti buddhiḥ sā pārtha
sāttvikī**

"O Partha! The intellect that knows action and withdrawal, what ought to be done and what ought not, fear and fearlessness, bondage and liberation

— that intellect is sattvic."

— Bhagavad Gita 18.30

And sattvic **dhṛiti** — the power to hold steady — is described this way:

**dhṛtyā yayā dhārayate manaḥ-prāṇendriya-
kriyāḥ**

yogenāvyabhicāriṇyā dhṛtiḥ sā pārtha sāttvikī

"O Partha! The unwavering resolve by which, through yoga, one holds the activities of the mind, the life-breath and the senses — that resolve is sattvic."

— Bhagavad Gita 18.33

Acharya Ji brings these very words — **duty and non-duty**, **bondage and liberation**, **pravritti** (the pull toward action), **avyabhicharini** (unwavering), **dharana** (holding) — down into examples from everyday life.

1. Absorbing the Mind Is Not Forbidden

Acharya Ji's teaching is not against entertainment. It is said plainly:

"If I am watching TV, watching TV is allowed. I don't say no — never. The nine rasas, you can enjoy all of them."

The **nine rasas** — love, humour, compassion, heroism and the other emotional flavours — are part of life itself. Acharya Ji continues:

"Watch a Bollywood picture too, no problem."

There is only one limit:

"Don't watch the extremely obscene, the filthy — a Guru will not allow that. But if you are watching something ordinary, something of Shukra, some serial — that's fine."

And when you watch, watch with your whole mind:

"Whatever you are watching, your mind has become absorbed in it. Keep the capacity to absorb the mind within you — meaning, do it with full focus."

2. The Sattvic Intellect Chooses First

Before the mind is absorbed, a choice is made, and it is the intellect that makes it:

"But if the sattvic intellect has joined with it, together with dhriti, then it will first choose whether to watch this serial or not, whether it will spoil my mind or not."

This is the Gita's discernment of **karyakarya** — what is worth doing and what is not.

3. Withdraw as Easily as You Absorb

Now comes the real test. Acharya Ji paints a scene at home:

"After that, your child comes there crying — 'Mother, I have to do this homework,' or 'Mother, I hurt my foot.' Now should you forget your duty — that you are also this child's mother, or this child's father?"

The answer is clear:

"The child's hurting, the child's crying — that is more important than your TV serial. This will come from the discerning intellect."

And here comes the central principle of this discourse:

"After that, you should also know how to pull your mind away from that serial just as fast. **As easy as it was to absorb the mind, you should know how to withdraw it just as easily.**"

What happens without this capacity, Acharya Ji shows with irony:

"Otherwise you will tell the child, 'Let your crying go on, let your blood flow; my serial will end in half an hour, then I'll come.'"

4. A ₹700 "Investment" and a Death

The second example is sharper still. Someone has had an accident, someone has passed away — and we are sitting in the theatre:

"'Arre, we had a three-hour picture. We sat in the theatre, we spent money on the picture. The ticket is ₹400, we took popcorn in hand, and ₹300 went on that — ₹700 has already been spent, an investment.... Arre, if he died, he died, it's fine.'"

Acharya Ji does not say that going to the picture was wrong:

"At that time this seemed right — perhaps you had gone with your wife to see the film, there was no problem. But a duty greater than that duty arrived. Because the sattvic intellect understands duty and non-duty."

So the question is not of good and bad, but of **lesser and greater duty** — and it is the sattvic intellect that recognises which duty is higher at that moment.

5. Sattvic Resolve: The Mind Goes In When You Want, Comes Out When You Want

This recognition is useful only when the mind is under our control. Here Acharya Ji connects the Gita's **avyabhicharini dhriti**, unwavering resolve:

"If one's power of holding has become sattvic, then the mind will be under one's control. Then whenever one wishes, one has set it — unwavering, on the Supreme, and on the higher duty. Then **as much as one can absorb the mind there, one also gains the power to withdraw it from there.**"

Acharya Ji also makes a subtle point — that for one who has taken this to heart, even watching TV is not a turning away from the Supreme:

"When I was watching TV, even through the TV I was attaining the Supreme — it was of the Supreme, unwavering. But at that very time some other duty arrived.... So here a higher duty has come, and then one must have the capacity to pull the mind out of there immediately."

What this resolve is, Acharya Ji puts in one sentence:

"The mind must be under my control — I can set it whenever I wish, I can withdraw it whenever I wish;
the mind is not to run me by its own will."

6. When the Mind Becomes the Master

What is the opposite? It is being a slave to **pravritti**, the compulsive pull:

"It's not that if I see something in the mall, I simply have to go. What was that point about pravritti — if you see liquor, you must go. **Now the mind has become the master, and you have become the slave.**"

"Saw a girl, lust awakened, went immediately — driven by the pull of desire."

Acharya Ji makes clear that control does not mean suppressing the mind, but keeping its direction in your own hands:

"That control should be in your hands.... So the control I am speaking of is — the mind getting absorbed in something, and coming out of it just as much. Its concentration power should be that strong."

7. Not Rajasic Wandering, but Sattvic Choice

Someone may say that repeatedly pulling the mind from one place and setting it on another is itself restlessness. Acharya Ji clears up this distinction:

"This work of the mind — every time, withdraw from here, set it here — this is not from a rajasic tendency. Now this is from a sattvic tendency. It is being done for a higher duty. **Here there is more bondage, here there is liberation — one should go here.** Pull it out immediately and bring it here."

The rajasic mind runs after desire; the sattvic mind recognises **bondage and liberation** and turns toward duty.

8. The Prime Minister and the World Cup

Finally, Acharya Ji gives a large-scale example. The national team has reached the World Cup final, and the Prime Minister is the chief guest:

"It is the Prime Minister's duty — today the World Cup is to be presented by the Prime Minister's own hands, to our country or to the other country. So being present there is necessary.... The Prime Minister won't come for some small triangular series, but the World Cup is a special event for a Prime Minister."

"The Prime Minister watched four overs, and a phone call came — 'Sahib, there has been a bomb blast in the neighbouring state.'"

"Now, would it be proper for the Prime Minister to keep sitting at this match? However important it is, even as the chief guest — tell me, would the mind have to be pulled out of that match immediately or not?"

Organising sport is also the king's work, but there is a higher duty:

"But above sports, in that king's duty, saving the lives of the people of the kingdom — would that come first or not?... **The mind must be pulled out of here immediately — in one jolt.** Here the king is only providing the people's entertainment; but there, the king must now also protect. Protection will be higher."

9. Only Such a Person Becomes a Good Upholder

The one who has this capacity is the one who can take care of others. Acharya Ji says:

"The one in whom this tendency exists will become a good upholder, a good one who holds things together, a good maintainer."

"This is the control over duty and non-duty: whether to set the mind here or there. A person of this quality can become a good maintainer. **Can become a good Vishnu. Can become a good sustainer. Can become a good protector.**"

Dharta — one who upholds and sustains. Lord **Vishnu** is the sustainer of creation; according to Acharya Ji, the person who gains such mastery over their own mind awakens within themselves that same quality of sustaining and protecting — for their family, society or nation.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 Entertainment is not forbidden.** The nine rasas, pictures, serials — all are allowed; only the extremely obscene and filthy are to be avoided.
- 2 The sattvic intellect chooses first** what to watch and what not to — whether it will spoil my mind or not.
- 3 As easy as it was to absorb the mind, you should know how to withdraw it just as easily.** That is true control of the mind.
- 4 Discern lesser and greater duty** — a crying child is higher than a serial, someone's death higher than a ₹700 ticket, and protecting the kingdom higher than the World Cup.
- 5 Let the mind be the servant, not the master.** One who runs the moment something is seen is a slave of pravritti.
- 6 Moving the mind is not rajasic restlessness** — when it turns toward higher duty and liberation, it is sattvic resolve.

7 **Only such a person becomes a good upholder — a sustainer, a protector, like Vishnu.**